

Chicago Tribune



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MONDAY, FEBRUARY 2, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



People ski at Wilmot Mountain ski resort in Wilmot, Wisconsin, on Thursday. The resort, located just over the Wisconsin border from Illinois, uses a combination of real and artificial snow. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Speaker: No quick vote on shutdown

Impasse on partial budget plan could stretch for few days

By Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — House Speaker Mike Johnson said Sunday it will be a few days before a government funding package comes up for a vote, all but ensuring the partial federal shutdown will drag into the week as Democrats and Republicans debate reining in the Trump administration's sweeping immigration enforcement operations.

Johnson signaled he is relying on help from President Donald Trump to ensure passage.

Trump struck a deal with senators to separate out funding for the Department of Homeland Security from a broader package after public outrage over two shooting deaths during protests in Minneapolis against Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

The measure approved Friday by the Senate would fund DHS temporarily, for two weeks, setting up a deadline for Congress to debate and vote on new restrictions on ICE operations.

"The president is leading this," Johnson, R-La., told "Fox News Sunday."

"It's his play call to do it this way," the speaker said, adding that the Republican president has "already conceded that he wants to turn down the volume" on federal immigration operations.

Johnson faces a daunting challenge ahead, trying to muscle the funding legislation through the House while Democrats are refusing to provide the votes for speedy passage.

They are demanding restraints on ICE that go beyond \$20 million for body cameras that

As the world gets warmer, winter sports get creative

From the Olympics in Italy to skiing the Wisconsin slopes, the race is on to adapt

By Adriana Pérez | Chicago Tribune

SALEM LAKES, Wis. — Under a blazing sun, dozens of skiers and snowboarders last week whizzed down a hill just north of the Illinois state line. Despite the blinding white of the slopes, most trails on Wilmot Mountain are typically replenished with artificial snow, which ski locations across the globe are increasingly relying on as pollution from burning fossil fuels changes the climate, increases average global temperatures and shortens winters.

And as lovers of winter sports from around the world prepare to watch one of the most popular sporting events kick off Friday, organizers for the Winter Olympics are also racing to adapt to the new reality.

Unseasonably warm winter temperatures in northern Italy — an average rise of 6.4 degrees Fahrenheit since it hosted the Winter Games in 1956 — and a reduced snowpack will require 2 million cubic yards of artificial snow to ensure consistent conditions for athletes. New snowmaking systems have been installed in Bormio for Alpine ski racing and ski mountaineering, and in Livigno for freestyle skiing and snowboarding events, according to The Associated Press.

"That has to be some kind of undertaking, to do that, cause you got to get it right. I mean, these kids are going quick. You want

their conditions to be good," said John Jedele, a resident of Antioch who skis at Wilmot Mountain in Wisconsin a few times a week.

For the most part, hobbyists, athletes and Olympians on the slopes — from northern Italy to southeastern Wisconsin — say they don't feel any changes in performance or experience between artificial and real snow.

"I can't tell the difference, and I'm an expert skier. Been skiing my whole life," said Chuck Randles, general manager at Wilmot Mountain of Vail Resorts. However, a warming world

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Turn to Budget, Page 9

ELECTION 2026

Governor throws Stratton \$5M lifeline

Pritzker's donation to PAC a big help for lieutenant governor's US Senate campaign

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker threw his two-term former running mate a \$5 million political lifeline, largely bankrolling a political action committee aimed at helping Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton win the Democratic nomination for U.S. Senate, recent federal campaign finance documents show.

Pritzker's Dec. 4 contribution to the Illinois Future PAC enabled the committee to book \$2 million in TV ads on the day after Christmas, while Stratton's own campaign fundraising has lagged, according to the documents filed with the

Federal Election Commission.

With Pritzker's contribution and another \$1 million from his cousin, Jennifer Pritzker, the Illinois Future PAC, which was funded by 10 donors and led by former Pritzker deputy campaign manager Quentin Fulks, began this year with \$4 million — almost four times the \$1.1 million in cash that Stratton's own campaign fund had to begin 2026, the FEC records showed. For the last three months of last year, Stratton's campaign raised \$1.1 million but spent \$912,379, according to the campaign finance records.

The filings of candidates seeking the March 17 primary nomination for the U.S. Senate seat being vacated by retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin showed Democratic U.S. Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi of Schaumburg continuing his torrid

Turn to Campaign, Page 5



Acting CTA President Nora Leerhsen at the CTA Damen Avenue Green Line station on Jan. 26. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Putting public transit on track

Acting CTA chief Nora Leerhsen lays out priorities after dodging fiscal cliff

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

When she was named acting president of the Chicago Transit Authority, Nora Leerhsen made a call to the agency's first female train operator.

Leerhsen, the first woman to lead the CTA, said she thanked Lena Phillips for breaking her own barrier on the rails in 1975. "Just being able to call her and tell her that there was a woman leading CTA was the most powerful aspect," Leerhsen said.

Phillips, who is now 81 and still a CTA rider, said she wished Leerhsen well. "Being the first for everything, it's a bit overwhelming at times," Phillips said.

Leerhsen, 43, has been at the CTA for more than a decade, starting as a legal intern before working her way up to chief of staff under former President Dorval Carter in 2018. A year ago, she took the wheel from Carter, who left the agency under pressure as it faced a looming fiscal crisis and years of rider complaints about bus and train service in the after-

math of the pandemic.

Though Sunday marked a full year at the helm of the agency, Leerhsen has yet to receive a nod from Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson to take the job on a permanent basis, and it remains unclear if he plans to tap her for the role.

Leerhsen sat down with the Tribune for a wide-ranging interview last week as she wrapped up her first year on the job.

The CTA's future in many ways

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INSIDE

Debate erupts over Indiana bill

Legislation that advanced out of the Indiana House would allow the governor to deploy a "military police force" of the Indiana National Guard throughout the state. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

5-year-old returns with dad to Minn.

Liam Conejo Ramos and his father, who were detained by immigration officers in Minnesota and held at an ICE facility in Texas, were released following a judge's order. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 27 Low 17

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 33 © Chicago Tribune

